2.7 Capernaum

(Capharnaum; Tell Hum; Kefar Nahum)

Summary of the description of the Property and its history and development

New Testament reference

- Teaching at Capernaum (Matthew 4:13-16, Luke 4:31-32)
- Demoniac healed in synagogue on Sabbath (Mark 1:21-28)
- Healing of Peter's mother- in-law & others (Mark 1:19-34)
- Jesus seeks isolation in prayer (Mark 1: 35-38)
- Healing of paralytic (Mark 2:1-12, Luke 5:17-26)
- Calling of Matthew (Mark 2:13-14, Luke 5:17-28)
- Matthew's Banquet (Mark 2:15-17, Luke 5:29-32)
- (reply) Why don't your disciples fast? (Mark 2:18-22, Luke 5:33-39)
- Healing of centurian's servant (Matthew 8:5-13, Luke 7:1-10)
- Two blind men healed (Matthew 9:27-31, Mark cf. 10:46-52, Luke (cf.18:35-43)
- Demonized dumb man healed (Matthew 9:32-34)
- Jairus' daughter raised & woman with hemorrhage healed (Mark 5:21-43, Luke 8:40-56)
- (disc) bread of life (John 6:22-59)
- Peter speaks for apostles (John 6:60-70)
- Payment of the temple tax (Matthew 17:24-27)
- (reply) "Which of us is the greatest?" (Matthew 18:1-5)

Description of Property

A relatively large site encompassing the remains of the town of Capernaum and its surroundings on land and in the Sea of Galilee offshore.

1. The Franciscan compound: Archaeological remains of the town of Capernaum, featuring -

- Authentic remains of 1st- century C.E. Capernaum including the House of St. Peter and other structural (including synagogue?) remains
- Domus Ecclesia (possibly the earliest ever found) and Byzantine octagonal church erected upon the House of St. Peter
- The largest and most magnificent Byzantine-period synagogue in Galilee, a conspicuous white limestone
- edifice existing side by side with the Byzantine Octagonal Church of St. Peter. Excavated and displayed Roman and Byzantine house-complexes, richly carved architectural elements, olive press, Roman milestone, inscriptions. Monumental Roman-period Mausoleum to the north.
- Modern memorial Church of St. Peter, Convent, unexcavated fallow areas and shoreline

2. The Greek-Orthodox compound: Excavated remains of Capernaum from the Roman, Byzantine and early Islamic periods; modern Church of the 12 Apostles

3. National Parks Authority visitor's center: New pilgrim's dock; ancient anchorage and shore-installations

History and Development

- 3rd-2nd millennia B.C.E. small settlement; 500 B.C.E. – 1500 C.E. consecutive village/town, peaking during the Byzantine period (pop. ca. 1,500). Historical landmarks:
- A small agricultural and fishing village in the time of Jesus
- Sanctification of the House of St. Peter in the late-Roman period, small Judeo-Christian community
- Church of St. Peter and Synagogue construction in the Byzantine period, town expansion
- Continued settlement in the Early Islamic period
- Late 19th century purchase and partition of land by Catholic-Franciscan and Greek-Orthodox churches
- 19th century research of ruined Synagogue sets in motion consecutive Franciscan archaeological excavation (systematic since the early 1970's) and restoration, continuing until today.
- Erection of modern memorial churches: The Greek-Orthodox Church of the 12 apostles (1925) and the Catholic Memorial Church of St. Peter (1990)
- Since the 1960's: In wake of continuous excavations, the Franciscan compound is greatly fostered and develops into a major pilgrimage site; in the Greek-Orthodox compound excavations (non-restored) are carried out in the 1980's, the modern church restored in 2000
- 1990's: land and underwater surveys and small salvage excavations in the Capernaum environs and along the shoreline between Capernaum and Tabgha
- 2000: Inauguration of National Parks Authority visitor's center and new pilgrim's dock

Detailed description of the Property and its history and development

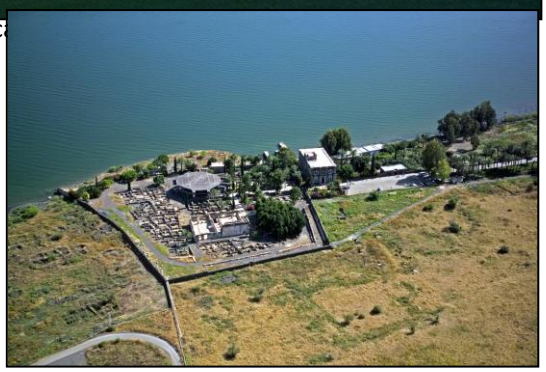
Name and Identification

The original semitic name of this site, *Kefar Nahum* (כפר נחום) is rendered in the Greek manuscripts of the gospels as *Capharnaoum* or *Capernaoum* (the latter giving way to the popular English spelling of ***Capernaum****)* while from medieval times and on the ruins on site have been termed 'Tanhum' (Hebrew) or 'Talhum' / 'Tell Hum' (Arabic). Where in the 19th and early 20th centuries C.E. the identification of Capernaum of New Testament fame was a matter of dispute, today it is unanimously identified with the site described forthcoming, encompassing the ruins of Tell Hum. The on-going excavations on this site have proven beyond doubt that here existed the 1st century C.E. village of Capernaum which, in later centuries, and in particular during the Byzantine period (4th-7th centuries C.E.), prospered and flourished, as witnessed by the discovery of grand religious edifices that were erected here during that period (Tzaferis 1989: 191-199; Loffreda 1993b: 14-17; 1997: 417).

Description of Capernaum at the present time

The site of Capernaum suggested here for nomination encompasses a 1.3 km long south-west – north-east stretch of land along the shore of the Sea of Galilee (its width varying between 100-400 m' between the Sea and the modern road to the north) and a parallel 150 m' wide stretch of the lake opposite the land-site. The site includes the visual remains of the ancient village and it's as-yet unexcavated presumed area, part of its peripheral necropolis, shore-installations and piers jutting out into the lake, and part of the lake itself facing the above. The site is presently owned and ministered by three separate compounds: The western, major, part owned by the Franciscan Custodians of the Holy Land; an eastern parcel of land, including the eastern parts of the ancient village of Capernaum, owned by the Greek-Orthodox Patriarchate of Jerusalem; and a government-owned area east of the Greek Orthodox Church, fostered by the National Parks Authority (Fig.83).

Fig. 83. Aerial Photo of Capernaum with the Francisc
the National Park visitor center and dock



The Franciscan Catholic compound: The property is surrounded by a stone wall since the end of the 19th century, is today a main attraction for thousands of Christian pilgrims and visitors world-wide, embracing within its midst the renown religious structures of the ancient Synagogue and of the sacred House of St. Peter (Figs. 84,95). As the decreed mission of the Franciscan Custodia is the protection of the ancient Christian sites in the Holy Land, the main activities carried out here in the last century have been archaeological excavation, preservation and restoration, with minimal modern development. A local asphalt road leads from the main road to two relatively small parking lots (one for buses, the other for private vehicles) near the entrance to the archaeological site that is open today to the public, in itself encompassing less than a quarter of the total Franciscan-owned area. Adjacent to the entrance is the two-story high Convent building built in 1923-1925 of non-protruding local limestone

and basalt stone, used in the past and present as the living quarters and offices of the local Custodia staff.

Artifacts on open-air display within the site are authentic ancient vestiges of the village of Capernaum – either *in-situ* structural remnants of the ancient settlement, ornamented architectural stone fragments (mostly originating from the grand Synagogue) or other archaeological relics. The display includes richly carved architectural elements, which are among the most renowned in ancient Synagogue archaeology, e.g. the stone-depiction of the Holy Ark (Fig. 85) and other ancient Jewish emblems, foremost of which was the *Menorah* depiction (Fig. 86). Other features on display include olive-oil pressing stones and a Roman-road milestone with a Latin inscription.

Fig. 84 Aerial Photo: of the Franciscan compound looking south

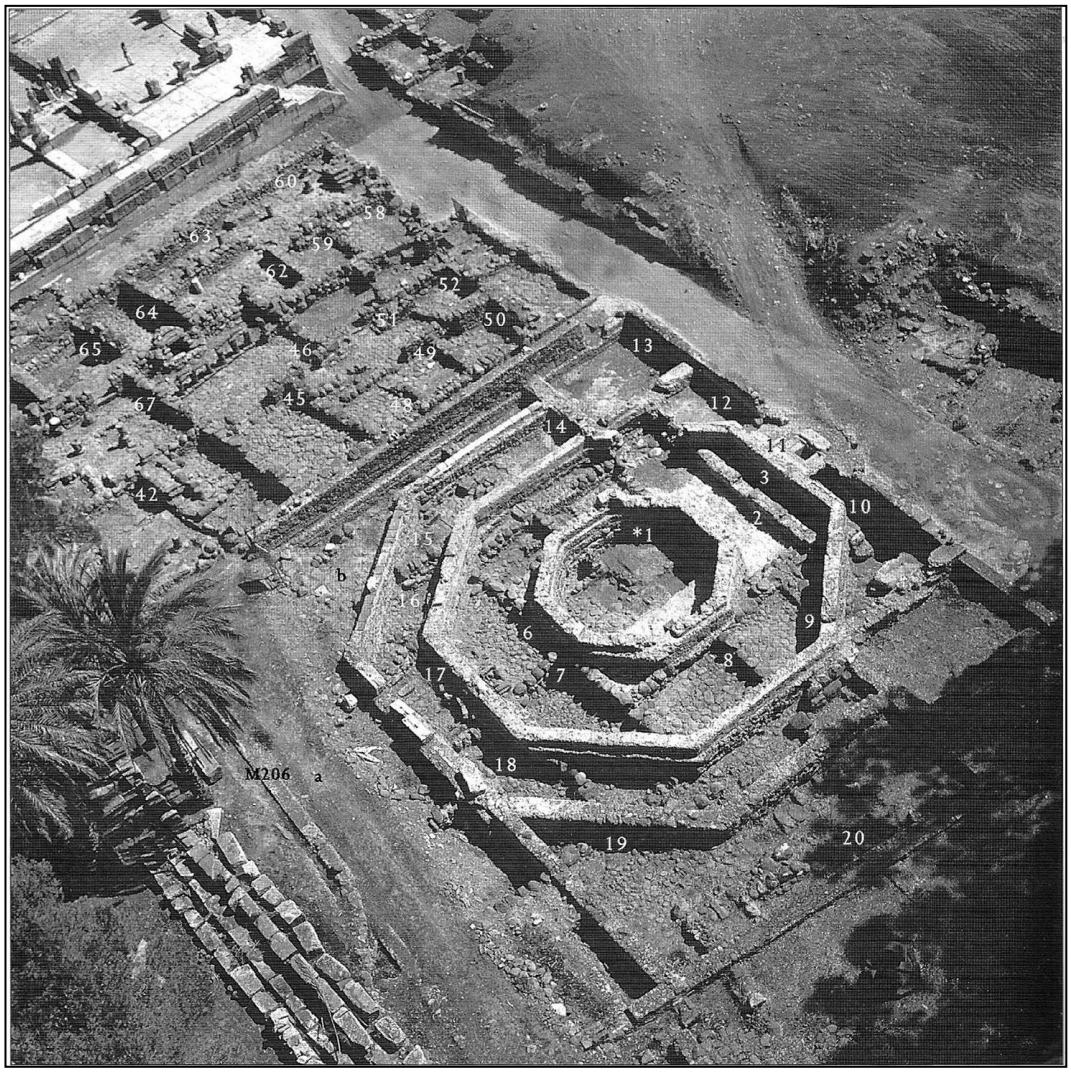
Fig. 85. An architrave from the synagogue with a relief of the Ark of Covenant

Eminently standing out above all other elements in the compound are the prominent edifices of the ancient, partly reconstructed, Byzantine-period Synagogue (Fig. 87). The synagogue's unique commanding appearance is due to its podium-based elevated position above its surroundings and especially to its design of white limestone richly-carved blocks which is in striking contrast to the contemporary, dreary basalt-built private buildings that surround the impressive structure. Inside the Synagogue is a flagstone-paved basilica-arranged 23 x 17 m' prayer-hall, surrounded on three sides by stone benches; adjacent to its east is an open courtyard and remains of a roofed portico. The synagogue's southern façade was flanked by a well-built stone-floored porch, from which a fine view of the village-area to its south (including the octagonal Church on the house of St. Peter) may be obtained. Of special significance, although not of grand appearance, are the earlier, possibly 1st-century C.E. (synagogue?) remains: these are the basalt foundation-walls that can be seen underlying the Grand Synagogue on its western and southern sides (a small sign on the synagogue's outer western wall brings this note to the visitors attention; see the archaeological survey for a short discussion on the interpretation of these finds).

Fig. 86. A capital from the synagogue with a relief of a Menorah

Fig. 87 Capernaum Synagogue looking north

The excavation areas surrounding the synagogue, albeit closed themselves to the regular visitor to the site, are easily observed from the outside, giving a unique perspective of the village architectural style. While most structures date to Byzantine times, some of them (including a section of the central part of Area 2 - between the Synagogue and Church - with a conspicuous windowed-wall, and part of the structures in the excavated area to the north of the guardian's booth) in fact most probably date back to early Roman (1st century C.E.) and even Hellenistic (2nd-1st centuries B.C.E.) times, however these are not specially marked, pending the publishing of the final excavation reports which will enable to determine the final



dating and stratigraphy of the structures.

South of the synagogue is the Insula Sacra (Fig. 88,), the revered traditional House of St. Peter on which stands today an imposing – although not towering – modern prayer edifice, St. Peter's Memorial, planned by the Italian architect Ildo Avetta. Uniquely hovering over the ancient 1st-6th remains (whom may be observed both from inside the building and from it's outside perimeter), this modern structure, dedicated in 1990 and whose walls are decorated with wooden panels depicting artistic biblical murals, is a quiet and serine haven for pilgrims (especially in the hot summertime) wishing to pray and to contemplate on this holy site, considered by many as being the Cradle of Christianity. Here also, under the modern structure, the visitor may best comprehend the archaeological stratigraphy of the site, for here a multilingual, well-drawn plan positioned above the remains greatly felicitates an understanding of what actually may be seen below (the 1st century remains of the actual House of St. Peter, the *Domus Eccclesia* and the Byzantine octagonal church overlying them; see archaeological review), greatly enhancing an appreciation of the importance of these finds.

Fig. 88. Aerial Photo: The Insula Sacra excavated remains of the 1st-6th centuries

The Greek Orthodox compound: The site is centered around the red-domed Church of the 12 Apostles, built in 1925 (Fig. 89). To its east is a small two-story convent, providing living quarters for the guardians of the site. Although excavations in the 1980's have revealed parts of the eastern part of the ancient village of Capernaum in the area to the west of the church (between it and the Franciscan compound), (see archaeological survey). The area of the convent and church has, however, in recent years been fostered by gardening endeavors and by a complete renovation of the church-interior. Between 1995 and 2000 the interior walls of the church were decorated with iconography by the Greek iconographer Constantine Dzumakis, colorfully depicting Saints and scenes from the Gospels. Today the Greek Orthodox Church promotes visiting the site.

Fig. 89. The Greek Orthodox Church of the Twelve Apostles

Fig. 90. Typical flora along the shores of Capernaum at the National Park visitor

National Parks Authority visitor's center: To the east of The Greek Orthodox compound is the National Parks Authority visitor's center (inaugurated in 2000) surrounded by natural flora and typical landscape (Fig. 90). It includes a modern pilgrim's dock that caters to hundreds of visitors who choose to reach the Capernaum shore by boat after sailing on the Sea of Galilee. A non-protruding stepped modern structure with restrooms, a small kiosk, water fountains and canals and a small but enlightening display of ancient stone anchors, artifacts from ancient Bethsaida and a mural of fishermen at ancient Capernaum, exists onshore opposite the pilgrim's dock. During the development of the park's land-premises no settlement remains of ancient Capernaum were found, but along the shoreline to the east and mostly to the west of the new pilgrim's dock are impressive unexcavated remains of triangular stone walls, piers i.e. stone jetties extending from the shore towards the lake for loading and unloading sailing vessels, a shore-promenade i.e. paved avenue along the shore reinforced by a stone wall, and a small (5-7 X 15 m') oval anchorage that can be discerned in low-tide adjacent to the pilgrim's dock on its eastern side. These are today the best-preserved and most easily visible and accessible remains of the extensive 700 m' long harbor of Capernaum that lines the shore along all three of the compounds described here (Fig. 91).

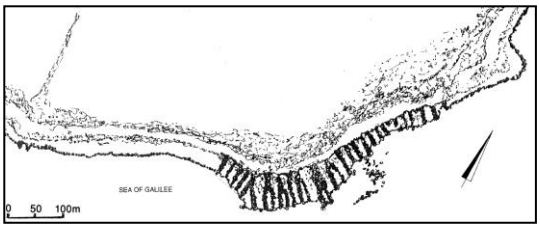


Fig. 91. Roman period (?) anchorage or boatyard, Capernaum Bay, after Stepansky.

Roman Mausoleum: Remains of a Roman Mausoleum excavated in 1976-1977 are visible at the southern edge of a banana plantation 250 m' due-north of the grand Synagogue, part of an extensive necropolis whose remains have been discerned since the 19th century in the fields to the north and east of the ancient village. The structure today hardly protrudes aboveground as only the foundations of the upper monument ('nephesh') have survived. The underground burial place ('hypogeum') is, relatively well preserved, built with large hewn blocks, and featuring a well-built corridor and central chamber that still house today five limestone sarcophagi.

History and Development of Capernaum

Outline of Archaeological Research and Development at Capernaum

Modern research and care for the site begin in the 19th century. Following is a concise historical survey of the main events pertaining to the archaeological research and modern development of Capernaum (Loffreda 1993a:292; 1993b:10-12; 1997: 417; Sapir and Ne'eman 1967: 34-38):

- 1838 – The American Geographer Edward Robinson describes the ruins of the synagogue as "the prostrate ruins of an edifice which, for expense, labour, and ornament, surpasses anything we have yet seen in Palestine".
- 1864 – Sir Charles Wilson carrys out limited soundings in the synagogue and surveys the site, mentioning two monumental tombs to the north (one of which, a grand Roman-period mausoleum, can still be seen today).
- 1894 – The western two-thirds of the ruins are acquired by the Franciscan Custodians of the Holy Land and fenced off with a stone wall still visible today; the synagogue area was covered with a protective layer of earth.
- End of 19th century - the remaining eastern third became the property of the Greek Orthodox Patriarchate of Jerusalem.
- 1905 – The German Archaeologists H. Kohl and C. Watzinger conduct the first controlled and well-recorded excavation of the synagogue, proposing a drawn reconstruction of the edifice which is still used by scholars today
- The Franciscan Brother W. von Menden conducts cleanings within the synagogue and limited excavations of village structures and the octagonal church.
- 1925 – The erection of The Church of the Twelve Apostles and a convent on the property of the Greek Orthodox Patriarchate by order of the Greek Patriarch Damianos
- 1905-1926 – Fr. G. Orfali partly uncovers the octagonal church and an Arab level of the town, and conducts extensive excavation and restoration work in the synagogue, the results of which were published in a monumental work (Orfali 1922).The convent building is erected in 1925.
- 1968-1991 - The archaeologists Fr. V.Corbo and Fr. Dr. S. Loffreda conduct extensive, consecutive and systematic excavations within the synagogue and House of St. Peter complexes, and within the village insula of houses surrounding these complexes. Work on the reconstruction of the synagogue was overseen by Fr. Corbo, who also reshaped the Franciscan property to cope with the ever increasing number of tourists and pilgrims visiting the site.
- 1976-1977 – Excavation of a Late-Roman period Mausoleum ca. 200 m' north of the synagogue by S. Loffreda
- 1978-1987 – Nine seasons of excavation were conducted by V. Tzaferis under the auspices of the Israel Department of Antiquities in the eastern Greek-Orthodox compound.
- 1990 – The completion and dedication of the New Memorial Church upon the traditional House of St. Peter
- 1995-2000 – Restoration work on the Greek-Orthodox Church of the Twelve Apostles and a fostering of its surrounding area
- 1990's – Land, coastal and underwater archaeological surveys and limited salvage excavations (mainly tombs and coastal harbor installations) undertaken by Israel Antiquities Authority archaeologists on the eastern, western and northern fringes of ancient Capernaum in wake of development plans pertaining to the establishment of the Israeli government-sponsored Kefar Nahum National Park encompassing the northern shore of the Sea of Galilee.
- 2000 – The inauguration of the Kefar Nahum National Park visitor's center and pilgrim's dock east of the Greek Orthodox compound.

- 1990's-2007 – Further excavations (mostly to the east of the synagogue and church of St. Peter), soundings, reconstruction work and fostering of the Franciscan compound, including the initializing of a full recording of all architectural elements being carried out by the Franciscan Archaeologist and Architect Fr. Stefano De Luca.

The History and Archaeology of Capernaum

(Based on: main Capernaum archaeological reports [see bibliography], Corbo 1993, Loffreda 1972, 1981, 1985, 1993a, 1993b, 1997; other references are designated within the text)

History: Isolated pottery sherds from the Early Bronze Age and some remains of walls from the Middle and Late Bronze Ages assert that already in the 3rd and 2nd millennia B.C.E. at least a small settlement existed here, on the northern shore of the Sea of Galilee. However, no remains have yet been discovered from the Iron Age (1200-586 B.C.E., Israelite period), probably explaining the absence of the name Kefar Nahum in the Old Testament. In the 5th century B.C.E. the site was resettled and expanded progressively within the next thousand years, reaching a peak during the Byzantine period (5th-6th Centuries B.C.E.).

Although specifically mentioned in historical sources only from the 1st century C.E., excavations have revealed that Hellenistic 2nd-1st centuries B.C.E. Capernaum was already at least a small town, with courtyard houses built of small to medium sized basalt stones. These houses continued in use for a number of centuries throughout the Early and Late Roman periods (1st-4th centuries C.E.), some of which are exposed today in the excavated areas of the Franciscan compound.

During the 1st century C.E. the gospels provide relatively much information on the settlement and its character during the time of Jesus: As a fishing and agricultural village in which lived Jewish families, artisans, merchants, scribes, tax collectors and publicans as well as at least one (retired?) Roman centurion who may have been serving as an administrative official (Reed 2000:162) and who built or financed the building of a synagogue for the local community (Luke 7:5) where Jesus preached and performed several of the miracles recorded in those sources. From the gospels (Mark 2:13-15; Mathew 9:9) that mention a customs house ('Telonion') at Capernaum we may also derive that the site was on the border between the Galilee within the Tetrarchy of Herod Antipas and the Golan allotted to Philip; the discovery of a milestone with an imperial Latin inscription from the 2nd century C.E. some 100 meters NE of the synagogue also attests to the proximity of the Roman east-west road that bypassed the northern flank of the village (Loffreda 1993a:292; 1993b: 18). The first disciples of Jesus, and five of the twelve apostles (Peter, Andrew, James, John and Mathew) were local residents and/or chosen here, while many more explicit individuals (e.g. Jairus, the synagogue official) and unnamed inhabitants are numerously mentioned in relation to the acts of Jesus in and around the site.

In the late Roman Period Capernaum continued to be a prominently Jewish town, as is indicated by the treatise of St. Epiphanes (315-402 C.E.) mentioning the village as one of the Jewish settlements of Galilee that forbade those of a different race to live among them (Tzaferis 1989: 194), reminiscent of the earlier 1st century recording of Jesus himself condemning the communities of Capernaum, Korazin and Bethsaida for not accepting his teachings (Mathew 11:20-24; Luke 10: 13-15). However, more than one contemporary Jewish literary sources mention a community of *Minnim* – Jewish-Christians – that existed at Capernaum (Midrash Qohelet Raba I:8, VII:26), and it is most probable that members of that community (probably a minority of the population of the town) as well as pilgrims from afar that sanctified the House of Peter, inscribing on its walls religious graffiti and turning it into a 'Domus-Ecclesia' (see below).

During the Byzantine period (324-640 C.E.) Capernaum prospered with an estimated mixed Jewish and Christian population size of ca. 1,500, as is witnessed by the construction in the 5th or 6th centuries of the large Synagogue (Fig. 92), the erection of the Octagonal Church above

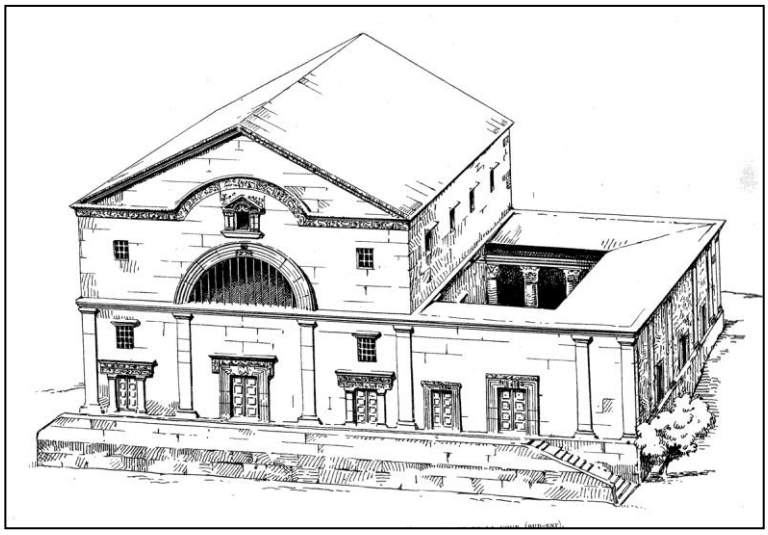


Fig. 92. A Drawn Reconstruction of the Capernaum Synagogue, after Orfali.

the house of St. Peter in the second half of the 5th century, and by the relatively rich architectural, ceramic, numismatic and other material finds from this period. An account by the pious pilgrim Egeria describing Capernaum in the late 4th century C.E. (a narrative reconstructed in 1137 by Peter the Deacon) includes a mentioning of a church that was made out of the house of the prince of the Apostles whose original walls were still standing (certainly referring to the Domus Ecclesia exposed on the site) and a synagogue 'made of dressed stones' (Wilkinson 1981: 194-196), while an anonymous pilgrim who visited the site ca. 570 C.E. describes the house of Peter as a 'basilica' (certainly referring to the octagonal church) (Tzaferis 1989: 205). These are rare instances of archaeological discovery whose identification is confirmed by literary sources.

During the Early Islamic period (7th-11th centuries C.E.) the site witnessed some regression, when the Synagogue and Octagonal Church were abandoned and a smaller village was built upon the ruins of the Byzantine town, reusing architectural elements from earlier structures, including the synagogue (Loffreda 1985). However, despite the overall reduced intensity and denseness of the settlement and a dearth of literary sources mentioning the site, excavations on the eastern wing of the site within the Greek-Orthodox compound (Tzaferis 1989) and on the eastern flank of the Franciscan compound (Loffreda 2001, 2002; De Luca 2003) have surprisingly revealed that Early Islamic Period Capernaum continued to flourish at least on its eastern side, to where the village's center of gravity probably shifted to after the Byzantine era. The material remains of this village include many cooking vessels, metal tools, baking ovens and millstones indicating the existence of well-to-do private homes and day to day life, while some of the architectural remains hint at the existence of public buildings, whose functions are as yet obscure. Noteworthy in particular is a hoard of 282 gold Dinars from the Umayid Period (7th-8th centuries B.C.E.) found in the Greek-Orthodox Compound excavations, showing for a large measure of prosperity at the site during that time-span (Tzaferis 1989).

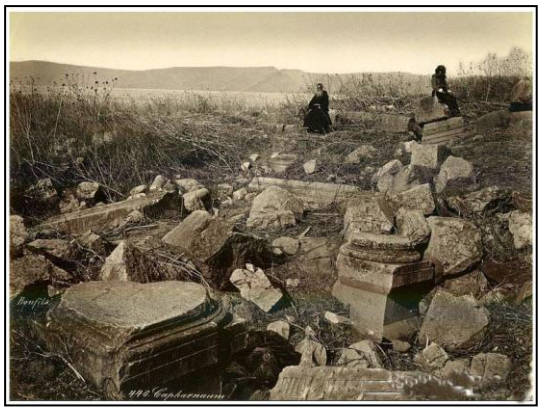


Fig.93 the ruins of Capernaum in the late 19th century, by Bonfils

During the Crusader period (11th-12th centuries C.E.), Capernaum was mostly abandoned, while during the Mamluke period (13th-15th centuries C.E.) recent excavations have revealed remains of structures east of the Insula Sacra (loffreda 2002, De Luca 2003). However, during most of the 2nd millennium C.E. Capernaum is numerously mentioned by travelers and pilgrims as an impressive ruin but not as an inhabited village (Fig. 93).

Archaeology: Save for some Third Millennium B.C.E. sherds, the earliest walls and pavements found in the Franciscan compound excavations date to the Middle and Late Bronze ages (2nd millennium B.C.E.), including a late-Bronze 13th century B.C.E. wall found in trench 21 under the western aisle of the synagogue. Although the settlement was renewed in the 5th century B.C.E., exposure of architectural remains mainly begins in the late-Hellenistic 2nd-1st centuries B.C.E., where small parts of the village have been exposed. The structures built in this period continued, with minor alterations and repairs, for centuries well through the Roman and Byzantine periods. These private houses, which include the revered house of St. Peter, were simple one-storey homes built of local basalt stone-walls and light wooden-beamed roofs, which clustered in units surrounding open courtyards where much of the daily life activities took place. From the building style and lack of certain architectural features as exposed in the Franciscan excavations (e.g. a lack of public drainage systems, water cisterns, public silos, strongly-based foundations and usage of mortar), and from the regular day to day finds unearthed, it can be deduced that Capernaum was a quite unpretentious agricultural and fishing village during the first centuries C.E., typical of rural Galilee in those times, although some other characteristics were most certainly also part of its economy (e.g. glass and purple-dye manufacture, commercial activity and toll-collecting). In the future this picture may change, for large parts of the settlement have yet to be excavated.

In the Greek-Orthodox compound, for example, soundings in the 1980's (yet to be published) have began to expose remains of public buildings and activities from the Roman and Byzantine periods which includes a roman bath (1st century C.E.? some interpret it as serving a military garrison to whom the roman centurion of New Testament fame was possibly connected; Matthew 8: 5-13, luke 7: 1-10), a building with large halls paved with dressed stone slabs (a central market?) and a massive late-Roman jetty and installations along the shore (Tsaferis and Peleg 1985, 1988-1999).

Recent excavations in the Franciscan compound east of the synagogue and of the Insula Sacra have also recently exposed Late-Byzantine well-planned living quarters and a public olive press (Loffreda 2002, 2003; De Luca 2003). Thus, in the Roman and Byzantine periods, it seems that Capernaum was more thriving than imagined until now, although this assumption seemingly pertains to the town some time after the period of Jesus himself. Furthermore, remains of an extensive harbor and numerous shore installations have been long-noted and surveyed all along the coast of Capernaum in all three compounds. As yet unexcavated, these remains probably date to the Roman and Byzantine times, although it would be incautious to connect them directly to the time of Jesus before a stratigraphic investigation has been conducted on them (Nun 1992: 40-42; Stepansky 1991: 89-90, 2003: 9*).

Capernaum's exposure of 1st century C.E. remains include parts of several simple private houses, and although these structures continue in use for centuries to come and were repaired or changed, their basic outline and foundations are rooted in the Late-Hellenistic – Early Roman periods (1st century B.C.E. – 1st century C.E.). Their simplicity and plain wooden-beam roofing is reminiscent of one of the narratives in the New Testament that took place in Capernaum: The story of the paralytic who was received by Jesus through an opening from above after removing a section of a roof in order do let him down (Mark 2: 4; Charlesworth 2006: 49-50). The small finds of these houses are of a typical domestic nature, and included many stone vessel-fragments which are a typical and confident indicator of Jewish identity.

Besides private-house remains, scrupulous excavations within the synagogue have shown without a doubt that underlying it were earlier basalt stone structures and pavements, and there is wide scholarly consent that some of these remains (especially a large paved area underlying the central nave, and possibly basalt walls underlying the later walls and stylobate) were probably vestiges of the synagogue of Capernaum in the time of Jesus, explaining the reason for the location of the monumental synagogue built later on this very site using the earlier structural remains as foundations for the new edifice (Strange and Shanks 1983; Loffreda 1993b:45; Levine 2000:67; Charlesworth 2006: 18-19).

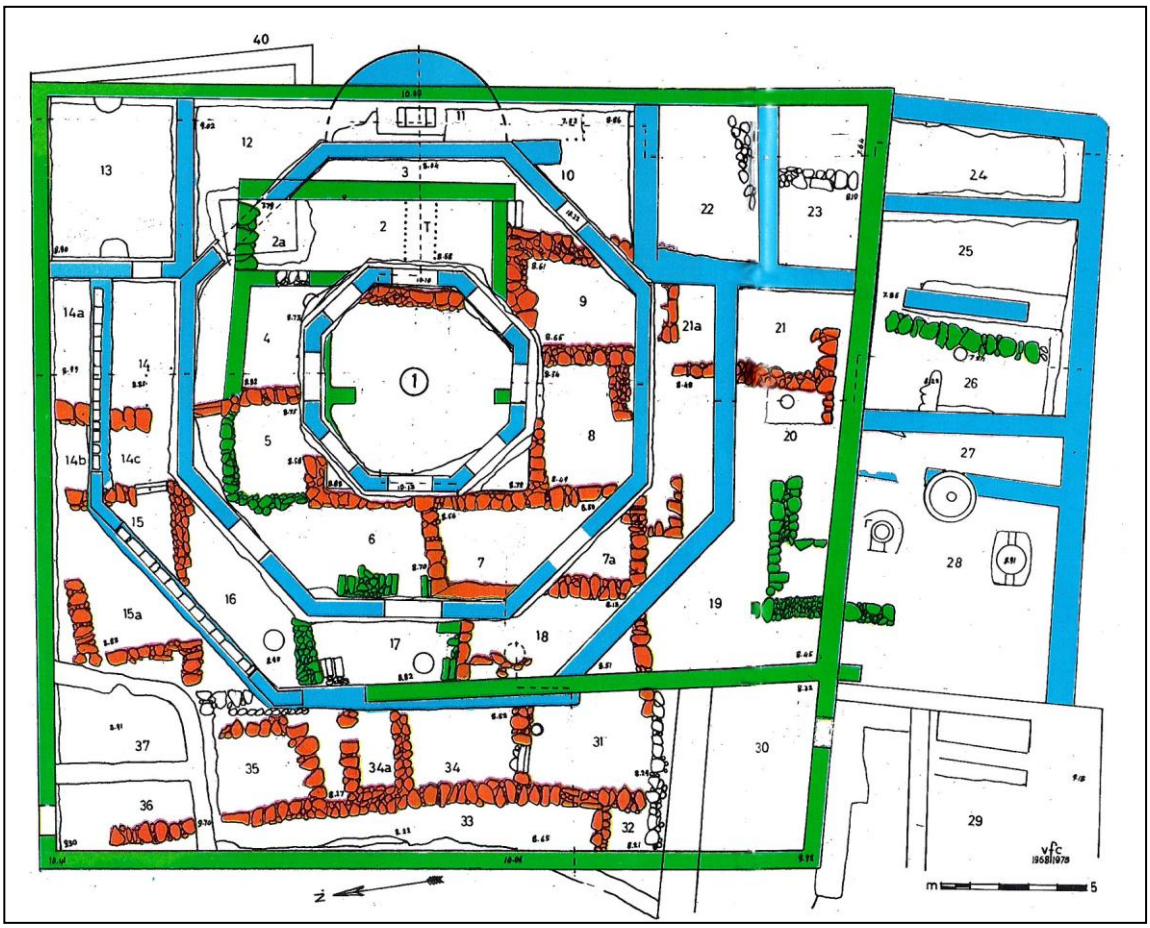


Fig. 94. General excavation plan of the Insula Sacra, after Loffreda: Level 1 (red) – private houses of the 1st century B.C.E; Level 2 (green) – the 4th century C.E. Domus-Ecclesia; Level 3 (blue) – the mid 5th century C.E. Octagonal Church

Most explicitly related to the time of Jesus is the well dated and stratified 1st century house traditionally identified as the House of St. Peter (Fig. 88,94). Its simple remains make it indistinguishable from the other houses in the early 1st century C.E. However, the changes made in the structure from the middle or late 1st century C.E. and on (the plastering of walls and pavements and especially the graffiti that were scratched on the walls) and a comparison of the small day-to-day finds of the earlier level (domestic day-to-day pottery and stone utensils) with the those of the later levels (storage jar and oil-lamp fragments, with an absence of the domestic corpus found in the earlier stratum), coupled with the focus on the house in later years when the octagonal church was erected, all clearly show that the site was venerated relatively soon after the time of Jesus and continued to be sanctified through the Byzantine period. These finds greatly support the excavator's opinion that this was, in fact, the site of the original 1st century C.E. House of St. Peter that developed not long after into a *Domus Eclesia,* on which, eventually, the Octagonal Church was erected (Strange and Shanks 1982**;** Corbo 1993; Loffreda 1993b: 52-67; Charlesworth 2006: 49-50)[1]

Two grand and striking architectural complexes stand out in their uniqueness, both being today the center of attraction for thousands of pilgrims and visitors to the Franciscan site: The Synagogue and the modern St. Peter Memorial structure overlying the ancient Insula Sacra (Fig. 95).

[1] For a more skeptic opinion on the validity of Peter's house under the Basilica, see Reed 2000: 143.

Fig. 95. Aerial Photo: of the Franciscan compound from the south

The imposing white-limestone synagogue complex (in which was centered the Jewish practice of reading the Torah and of ritual prayer) is the largest (30 X 23 m' including the eastern court) and most well-constructed and ornamented synagogue in ancient Palestine (Fig. 87,92). Its main features include a prayer hall with three monumental entrances in its southern wall, an eastern courtyard and a southern porch. The floor of this two-storied structure was paved with flagstones, on which were built Corinthian columns that sat on raised pedestals on a sturdy stylobate; the synagogue was decorated with many richly carved reliefs, some with typically Jewish emblems (like the menorah and a depiction of the Holy Ark (Fig. 86); the *Hexagram* [six-pointed 'Star of David' and *Pentagram* [five-pointed 'seal of Solomon'] carved on several frieze-stones, however, are not originally of Jewish origin) and most others with sophisticated Roman-style ornamentation (e.g. the Roman imperial eagle, and other typical faunal and floral motives). Engraved on two of the columns were two inscriptions, one Greek and the other Aramaic: (Greek)"Herod, son of Mo[ni]mos, and Justus, his son, together with [his] children, erected this column"; (Aramaic) "Halfu, the son of Zebidah, the son of Yohanan, made this column. May he be blessed. According to the excavators Loffreda and Corbo the date of construction for the building – which was carried out over the course of a century – is the 5th century C.E., based on the material (mostly coins) found in the excavated trenches under the flagstone floor.

Other scholars place the construction slightly later to the 6th century (Magness 2001:24-25) while others maintain (as was commonly held until the Franciscan excavations beginning in 1968) that the architectural style is typically late-Roman, and therefore a previous grand synagogue which was constructed on the site during the late-Roman period (2nd-4th centuries) must have been thoroughly taken apart and reconstructed in the 5th or 6th centuries reusing

the former stones (Foerster 2007). Another possibility was raised in the past that the Byzantine synagogue was built with Roman-period imported stones from some other site(s) in the Galilee (Maoz 1999); in fact, the possibility that Tiberias was the source for Capernaum's architectural elements (shipped there by boat?) was recently raised after parts of a monumental lintel very similar to some of those in Capernaum were found incorporated in secondary use in the walls of the recently discovered Crusader castle of Tiberias (Stepansky 2004a, 2004). Underlying the synagogue complex were walls and pavements from the Roman and Hellenistic periods; while the demise of the building seems to have been in the 7th century C.E., possibly in wake of the Arab conquest of 636 C.E.

Less than 30 m' south of the synagogue is the Insula Sacra: part of one of the living quarters in Roman period Capernaum, in which the traditional house of St. Peter was identified and sanctified in antiquity. Prolonged excavations of the site have revealed a Late-Hellenistic – Early Roman period house complex and courtyard, similar to the others in the village. However, in contrast to them, a central 6.5 x 7 m' room within the complex (termed by the excavators room no. 1) was architecturally accentuated in later years: in the 4th century C.E. when renovations were done (mainly additions, leaving most of the walls of the original house intact – as witnessed by the pilgrim Egeria) including the addition of an enclosure wall surrounding the house complex, and in the 5th century when a concentric octagonal-walled, mosaic-paved (dominated by a peacock motive) and roof-tiled church with an apse on its eastern wall was built on the site, the core of which was set exactly over the walls of the centralized room. This octagonal church is a-typical of churches in the country; only two others (Mt. Grizim above Nablus and Mar Elias near Jerusalem) have similar plans. Moreover, in contrast to other households, excavations within the focused room revealed eleven superimposed layers of plastered pavements, and of most importance - hundreds of fragmentary pieces of decorated plaster with geometric, floral and other motives, among them approx. 100 bearing signs of religious symbols and graffiti in Greek, Latin, Aramaic and Syriac, all originally deriving from the painted inner walls of the structure. These finds have been interpreted by the excavators as signs of sanctification of the traditional house of St. Peter as early as the late first century C.E. (Corbo 1969: 44, 53-54; 1993; Loffreda 1997:418), already being employed as a *Domus Ecclesia* ('House Church'), which underwent renovation in the 4th century C.E., and on which in the 5th century the full-fledged octagonal church was erected. .

Excavations in both the Franciscan and Greek-Orthodox compounds during the last few decades have added much to our knowledge of post-Byzantine Capernaum; today there is a wide consent that Capernaum continued to exist and even thrive throughout the Early Islamic period, although it is not known to what extent – if at all - did a Christian or Jewish community subsist at the site among the Arab newcomers (in Tiberias, e.g., firm remains of large Christian and Jewish communities have been found in excavations).

Since the 19th century, the existence of tombs in the northern and eastern periphery of Capernaum has been noted in various references (including two monumental ones, the location of one has since been lost); their distribution to the east reaches the Corazim Brook (map ref. 20465 25465) although the most dense burial field seems to be north and north-east of the center of the ancient village, in the area of the excavated Roman mausoleum and to its east (Corbo 1977; Stepansky 2003:9*; Gal and Hanna 2000; Loffreda 2005: 187-191, figs. 317-324a).